

► Folk tales

Storytelling was the realm of women in many indigenous tribes. Inuit women in western Alaska wore these masks on their fingers during dances, and used their hands to relay stories of the cosmos—represented by the mask's circle.



say in choosing the leader of their tribe, could divorce their husbands, and determine how many children they had. In the Cherokee nation, a Ghigau, or “war woman,” sat in council meetings with war chiefs, while Blackfoot tribes had just as many female shamans as male.

The earliest clashes between European and Native American cultural practices revolved around agriculture. Many native people on the East Coast of North America considered farming to be women's work.

Native American women planted and tended corn, clearing land, and moving when necessary to avoid depleting the soil. In Europe, however, farming was a man's job. The settlers paid little attention to native agricultural practices. As a result, many of the colonists did not survive the first winter because they had not adapted their farming methods to suit the American landscape.

Sexual contact

Differing sexual mores between Europeans and indigenous nations led to conflict. Many settler accounts describe Native American women as being sexually lascivious. Jesuit accounts condemned the Huron nation (in what is now Ontario, Canada), describing a healing ceremony in which a group of Huron women slept with the young men of the town in a group ceremony. However, some colonizers' descriptions of women as sexually aggressive were made simply to hide their own sins. When Spanish conquistador Hernán Cortés arrived at Mexico's Yucatán Peninsula, local leaders gave him women dressed in gold as gifts to breed with. Cortés and his men baptized these women, taking them as slaves and concubines. Calling them “horse-hair savages,” the men refused to acknowledge *mestizo* (mixed-race) children born of such unions, and often abandoned these women when they returned to Spain.

► Subjects of curiosity

Explorers often made paintings and sketches of the native people they encountered. John White created this illustration during his time in Ossomocomuck, coastal South Carolina, depicting the wife of a chief with her daughter.



BIOGRAPHY MALLINALI

Born in Coatzacoalcos, central Mexico, in 1502, Mallinali was given to conquistador Hernán Cortés by a Mayan prince. Cortés saw her intelligence and took her as a translator, guide, and concubine in his conquest of Mexico (1519–1521). Her knowledge of Náhuatl and multiple Mayan dialects made her a big asset to the Spanish colonizers, and she was both vilified as a traitor to her people and seen as a victim, symbolizing all such unequal relationships between conquerors and natives.

